Ms. *Ros-Lehtinen*. Thank you so much.

Chairman Berman. I recognize the ranking member for 5 minutes, then the gentlelady from Texas.

Ms. *Ros-Lehtinen*. Thank you.

Well, thank you for wonderful testimony, very insightful. And, General, I am a proud stepmom of two Marines. My stepson and daughter-in-law served in Iraq and she served in Afghanistan as well. Now they are back home at the U.S. Naval Academy. And they are proud of their service. And we congratulate you for the great contributions you have made in the past, present and the future. You have worn our nation's uniform proudly.

I wanted to ask you gentlemen about the opium trade and the projections and what we can do about it. As all of us know, in spite of ongoing international efforts fighting Afghanistan's narcotic trade, the U.N. officials have estimated a record opium poppy crop was produced last year, supplying 93 percent of the world's illicit opium. And clearly, opium poppy cultivation, and drug trafficking constitute serious strategic threats to our security and to the stability of the country of Afghanistan. It jeopardizes the success of post-9/11 counterterrorism, and reconstruction efforts. In a nutshell what has worked, what has not worked with our counternarcotics policy there and what must we do to arrest this trend in the future?

Ambassador Pickring. It is hard to see, Ms. Ros-Lehtinen, that much has worked. At least as part of our recommendation that we need to get a grip on the problem through a gradual but continuing transformation of our efforts. We made suggestions. One of those is that obviously we need to find the right substitute crops and the right markets for them. And we need to find a way to support this transition from growing to selling so that we are not putting people in a position where they grow something they cannot dispose of.

There has been a strong suggestion by some people that fruit and tree crops are particularly important in the region and there will be a strong market for those. I am not a USDA specialist but it seemed to be interesting. And, of course, once you get invested in that it is hard to get disinvested, hard to pull up the trees once they get growing. But we do know that the drug lords provide everything from——

Ms. Ros-Lehtinen. Transportation, pick-up.

Ambassador Pickring [continuing]. Transportation,——

Ms. Ros-Lehtinen. Yes.

Ambassador Pickring [continuing]. Agricultural extension, loans, microfinance.

Ms. Ros-Lehtinen. I am going to cut you off, Ambassador, just to get the General's take on it.

Ambassador Pickring. Okay.

Ms. Ros-Lehtinen. Because I only have 1 1⁄2 minutes.

Ambassador Pickring. I follow that.

Ms. Ros-Lehtinen. Thank you, sir.

Ambassador Pickring. So we need to do that. We also need to get some of the middlemen who are also government officials out of the business.

General Jones. Thank you. I really appreciate that question because I think the direction of Afghanistan is directly linked to our inability, our international inability to deal with the narcotics problem. Ninety percent of the products produced, the illegal products are sold on the streets of European capitals. That money comes back and funds the insurgency, buys the weapons that kills and wounds NATO soldiers and ours as well. And it is really to me at the

Copyright © 2010. Nova Science Publishers, Incorporated. All rights reserved.

Combating Islamic Militancy and Terrorism in Pakistan's Border Region, Nova Science Publishers, Incorporated, 2010. ProQuest Ebook Central,